WHITE PAPER · VERSION 1.0

The 18 Ways AI Models Charge

A Formal Analysis of AI Pricing Mechanisms, From the Per-Token Meter to Legacy Model Names

> Every pricing mechanism I can document on at least one of 106 tracked models from 18 vendors, ranked from most common to least common, with what to watch, how to optimize and what to avoid for each one.

18	106	18
MECHANISMS	TRACKED MODELS	VENDORS

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Executive Summary

I track 106 priced models from 18 vendors. Across them I count 18 distinct ways a vendor turns usage into a charge. Two are close to universal. Every model prices input and output tokens, and 93 of the 106 discount cached input. Everything else is a twist on those two meters, and the twists are where budgets break.

The common twists change the price of the same token. A cache write costs 1.25x input on Anthropic, the same as input at most vendors, and nothing at all on 26 paid models. Batch cuts the price in half on 39 tracked models. Speed tiers push it the other way. OpenAI Fast is 2x standard, Anthropic fast mode takes Claude Opus 5.5 from $4/$20 to $8/$40, and OpenAI Ultrafast reaches 6x. On 22 models a prompt-size band reprices the whole request once the prompt crosses a line: above 272,000 tokens on OpenAI, at 200,000 on xAI and Gemini 2.5 Pro, above 100,000 on Claude Haiku 5.5. Data residency adds 10 percent at Anthropic and OpenAI, and on Claude served through regional Amazon Bedrock and Google Cloud endpoints.

The less common twists add new meters. Web search costs $10 per 1,000 calls at Anthropic and OpenAI. Z.ai and MiniMax charge $0.01 per call, which works out to the same price. Google charges $14 per 1,000 after 5,000 free requests a month. Code containers bill by the container-hour or by the 20-minute session. Gemini charges $0.50 per million tokens per hour to keep an explicit cache alive. DeepSeek halves its prices outside two weekday UTC windows and treats every Chinese public holiday as off-peak. Prices also move on a calendar. Gemini 4 Argon doubles on December 1, 2026, and three Gemini Flash models double on January 1, 2027. Claude 4.7 and later use a tokenizer that produces about 30 percent more tokens for the same text, which raises the bill without touching the price.

My operating rule is simple. Every mechanism needs a meter, a dated price and a stacking rule. If a billing system cannot meter a mechanism, it should refuse the request that triggers it instead of billing it at the wrong price. Bill a 1-hour cache write on Moonshot Kimi K3.1 Pro at the 5-minute price and you collect $2.00 of the $4.00 owed on that line. Let a web search through unmetered and you lose $10 for every 1,000 calls.

HOW I COUNTED

I counted prevalence against my live Tariff as read on October 24, 2026: 106 priced models from 18 vendors (Alibaba, Amazon, Anthropic, Cohere, DeepSeek, Google, Meta, Microsoft, MiniMax, Mistral, Moonshot, OpenAI, StepFun, Tencent, TypeSafe, Xiaomi, xAI, Z.ai).

For mechanisms my Tariff stores directly (token prices, cache prices, prompt-size bands, peak and off-peak bands, $0 lines, scheduled step-ups, per-request fees), the count is the number of tracked models that carry the mechanism. For mechanisms vendors publish but my Tariff does not store as a separate line (batch,

speed tiers, web search, data residency, storage, runtime), the count is the number of the 106 models whose vendor's own pricing page offers it. I mark those counts "exposed."

Every mechanism on the list is carried by at least one tracked model. The ranking measures how many tracked models can produce a charge, not how often the charge appears on invoices. The 106 models are the set I track, not the whole market.

Prices are US dollars per million tokens unless stated. A pair such as $4/$20 means $4 per million input tokens and $20 per million output tokens. Any claim I could not confirm against a vendor's own page or my live Tariff carries the label UNVERIFIED.

The 18 Mechanisms, Ranked by Prevalence

#	MECHANISM	TRACKED MODELS (OF 106)	VENDORS (EXAMPLES)
1	Per Input and Output Token	**106**	All 18
2	Cached Input Read Discount	**93**	17 of 18 (not TypeSafe)
3	Per-Call Server Tool Fees	**72 exposed**	Anthropic, OpenAI, Google, xAI, Z.ai, MiniMax, Xiaomi, DeepSeek
4	Separate Cache Write Charge	**52**	Anthropic, OpenAI, Alibaba, Z.ai, Xiaomi, Amazon, DeepSeek, Mistral, Cohere
5	Batch Discount	**39 exposed**	Anthropic, OpenAI, Google, Xiaomi (Mistral UNVERIFIED)
6	Free Tiers and $0 Price Lines	**30**	Google, Z.ai, Xiaomi, Amazon, TypeSafe
7	Speed, Priority and "Highspeed" Tiers	**29 exposed**	OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, MiniMax, Moonshot, Xiaomi
8	Container and Session Runtime Fees	**28 exposed**	Anthropic, OpenAI
9	Data Residency and Regional Price Lists	**23 exposed**	Anthropic, OpenAI, Bedrock, Google Cloud, Xiaomi, Tencent, Alibaba
10	Prompt-Size (Long Context) Bands	**22**	OpenAI, xAI, Google, Anthropic, MiniMax, Alibaba
11	Cache Write Priced by Retention Time (TTL)	**22 exposed**	Anthropic, OpenAI, Moonshot
12	Flex (Slow, Cheap Synchronous) Tier	**22 exposed**	OpenAI, Google
13	Hidden Token Overhead	**13 exposed**	Anthropic, OpenAI
14	Reasoning (Thinking) Tokens Billed as Output	**10+ verified**	Google, Alibaba, xAI and others

#	MECHANISM	TRACKED MODELS (OF 106)	VENDORS (EXAMPLES)
15	Cache and File Storage by Time	**8 exposed**	Google, OpenAI (Z.ai "limited-time free")
16	Promotional Pricing and Dated Step-Ups	**6**	Google, OpenAI, MiniMax
17	Time-of-Day and Day-of-Week Bands	**3**	DeepSeek
18	Legacy Model Names Billed as a Different Model	**1**	DeepSeek (xAI naming rule documented, not counted)

The Mechanisms

01 NAME · MECHANISM 1 OF 18 Per Input and Output Token

106 of 106 models

DESCRIPTION

This is the base meter. The vendor prices input (prompt) tokens and output (completion) tokens separately, per million. Output almost always costs more.

EXAMPLE

Claude Opus 5.5 lists $4.00 input and $20.00 output. Across the 106 models I track, input runs from $0.03 (Z.ai GLM-OCR) to $30.00 (OpenAI gpt-5.5-pro), and output tops out at $180.00, also on gpt-5.5-pro. The output-to-input ratio clusters at a few values.

OUTPUT-TO-INPUT RATIO	TRACKED MODELS
5x	26
4x	17
6x	11
3x	10

MODELS THAT USE IT

All 106 tracked models from all 18 vendors.

THINGS TO WATCH

- Output-heavy work such as agents, code generation and long reports is priced on the expensive side. At a 5x ratio, one output token costs as much as five input tokens.
- Token counts do not compare cleanly across vendors, or even across generations of one vendor's models (see Mechanism 13).
- Some vendors price output at $0. TypeSafe Jev bills $0.042 input and $0 output.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Cap output length with a max-tokens setting and ask for structured, terse output.
- Route by task. Claude Haiku 5.5 at $0.10/$0.50 against Opus 5.5 at $4/$20 is a 40x spread inside one vendor.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Comparing models on input price alone.
- Treating a list price as the effective price. Nearly every mechanism that follows changes it.

NAME · MECHANISM 2 OF 18

02 Cached Input Read Discount

93 of 106 models

DESCRIPTION

When a request reuses a prompt prefix the vendor already holds in cache, those tokens bill at a cache-hit price below the normal input price.

EXAMPLE

VENDOR AND MODEL	CACHE READ PRICE
Anthropic, most models	0.1x input
Anthropic Opus 5.5 and Sonnet 5.5	0.05x input
Anthropic Fable 5.1	0.025x input ($0.25 against $10.00)
DeepSeek Flash, off-peak	$0.003 cached against $0.15 uncached (98 percent off)

Across tracked models the most common ratio is 0.1x (37 models), then 0.2x (11 models) and 0.25x (9 models).

MODELS THAT USE IT

93 of 106 models across 17 vendors. TypeSafe is the exception. Five models price a cache read at the full input price (three Alibaba models, plus OpenAI gpt-5.5-pro and o3-pro). Six paid models publish no cache price at all (four TypeSafe models, two Z.ai models). The last two are Google Gemma 4 12B and 31B, which carry all four price lines (input, output, cache read and cache write) at $0. That makes 93 + 5 + 6 + 2 = 106.

THINGS TO WATCH

- Discounts vary 30-fold, from 0.0083x (Xiaomi MiMo-V2.6-Pro) to 0.25x. Only 37 of the 93 discounting models (40 percent) charge exactly 0.1x. A blanket "90 percent off cached input" assumption is wrong for the other 56 (60 percent), and for 69 of all 106 tracked models (65 percent) once you add the at-par, unpriced and free models.
- On Anthropic, a cache hit also refreshes the cache timer.
- Some models cache only implicitly. Google says Gemini 4 Argon supports "implicit caching only (explicit caching is not supported)."

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Put stable content first (system prompt, tool definitions, reference documents) and variable content last, so the prefix matches.
- Keep a conversation on one model. Caches do not carry across models.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Reordering tools or injecting a timestamp at the top of the prompt. Either one breaks the prefix.
- Billing a model with no published cache price as if it had one. A cache price with no first-party basis is an invented number.

NAME · MECHANISM 3 OF 18

03 Per-Call Server Tool Fees

72 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

When the vendor runs a tool on its own servers (web search, grounding, file search), it charges per call or per 1,000 calls. That fee sits on top of the tokens the tool's results add to the prompt.

EXAMPLE

VENDOR	TOOL	PRICE	NOTES
Anthropic	Web search	$10 per 1,000 searches plus tokens	A failed search is not billed. Web fetch has no extra fee.
OpenAI	Web search	$10 per 1,000 calls plus content tokens	The non-reasoning preview tool is $25 per 1,000 with free content tokens.
OpenAI	File search	$2.50 per 1,000 calls	
Google	Grounding with Search or Maps (Gemini 3 and newer)	$14 per 1,000 after 5,000 free requests per month	The allowance is shared across models.
Google	Grounding on Gemini 2.5	$35 per 1,000 grounded prompts (Search), $25 per 1,000 (Maps)	After the free daily allowance.
Z.ai	Web search	$0.01 per use	
MiniMax	web_search	$0.01 per request	
Xiaomi	Overseas search	$5 per 1,000	
DeepSeek	Search and Fetch	$0.75 per 1,000 successful requests	Free until 00:00 Beijing time on November 1, 2026 (16:00 UTC, 11:00 AM Central, on October 31).
xAI	Web, X search, code and collections tools	$2.50 to $10 per 1,000	UNVERIFIED. From my October 20 review; I did not fetch the xAI tool page again for this article.

On Google, one customer request can trigger several billed searches.

MODELS THAT USE IT

72 exposed models: Z.ai 18, OpenAI 16, Anthropic 12, Google 10, xAI 8, Xiaomi 3, DeepSeek 3, MiniMax 2. Moonshot also prices its built-in tools, but I have not verified the rate.

THINGS TO WATCH

- The fee is per call, not per answer. One prompt can fan out into many searches.
- The tool's results come back as input tokens and stay in context on later turns.
- Free allowances are shared across models and reset monthly or daily, depending on the model family.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Cap tool calls per request.
- Prefer token-only tools where the vendor offers them, such as Anthropic web fetch and Google URL context.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Letting a server tool through a billing layer that cannot count it. If the call count is not metered, refuse the tool instead of billing tokens only.

NAME · MECHANISM 4 OF 18

04 Separate Cache Write Charge

52 models

DESCRIPTION

The vendor bills the cache write as its own line. Depending on the vendor, the write costs more than input, the same as input, less than input, or nothing.

EXAMPLE

TREATMENT	EXAMPLE
Premium	Anthropic 5-minute write at 1.25x input: Opus 5.5 $5.00 against $4.00
Premium	OpenAI newer models, 30-minute write at 1.25x: gpt-6-astra $12.50 against $10.00
Discount	DeepSeek V4 Pro write $0.435 against $1.32 peak input. UNVERIFIED. DeepSeek's current page publishes no write price; my Tariff carries the figure from an earlier source.
Free	Z.ai lists cached input storage as "Limited-time Free" on all paid GLM models
Free	Xiaomi lists "Cache Write: Limited-time Free"

MODELS THAT USE IT

52 models price the write differently from input: 21 at a premium (Anthropic 12, OpenAI 7, Alibaba 2), 5 below input and 26 paid models with a $0 write. Another 52 price the write at par with input: 50 paid models plus Gemma 4 12B and 31B, whose $0 cache-write line equals their $0 input. The last 2, TypeSafe jev-1.13.0 and jev-1.14.0, have no cache-write line at all. That makes 52 + 52 + 2 = 106. In total, 28 models carry a $0 cache-write line: the 26 paid models plus the 2 Gemma models.

THINGS TO WATCH

- A write premium means caching loses money if nothing reads the prefix again. Anthropic says a 5-minute write pays off after one read and a 1-hour write after two.
- "Limited-time free" has no end date on either the Z.ai page or the Xiaomi page.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Cache only the prefixes you expect to reuse within the retention window.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Treating a free write as permanent. Record it as a promotion and check it again at every price review.

05 Batch Discount

NAME · MECHANISM 5 OF 18

39 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

You submit work asynchronously and accept a delay, typically up to 24 hours. In exchange you pay roughly half.

EXAMPLE

MODEL	STANDARD	BATCH
Anthropic Opus 5.5	$4/$20	$2/$10 (50 percent off input and output)
OpenAI gpt-6-astra	$10/$50	$5/$25
Google Gemini 4 Argon	$2/$10	$1/$5
Xiaomi MiMo-V2.6-Pro	$0.435/$0.87	$0.2175/$0.435

MODELS THAT USE IT

39 exposed models: OpenAI 16, Anthropic 12, Google 9, Xiaomi 2. Mistral's pricing page has a Batch tab, but I did not extract its rates, so Mistral batch pricing is UNVERIFIED. xAI says "not every model accepts Batch API requests," and its batch rates are UNVERIFIED.

THINGS TO WATCH

- On Anthropic, the batch discount stacks with caching.
- Not every model or mode qualifies. Xiaomi Ultraspeed, Anthropic fast mode and Anthropic Managed Agents have no batch option.
- OpenAI's batch table omits cached-input discounts for several older models, gpt-4.1 among them.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Move evaluations, backfills, classification and nightly reports to batch.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Using batch for anything a user is waiting on.

NAME · MECHANISM 6 OF 18

06 Free Tiers and $0 Price Lines

30 models

DESCRIPTION

The vendor prices a model, a unit or a usage band at zero, either permanently or for a limited time.

EXAMPLE

- **Fully free models.** Google Gemma 4 is free tier only and listed as "Not available" on paid. I track two sizes, 12B and 31B. Z.ai also lists GLM-4.7-Flash, GLM-4.5-Flash and GLM-4.6V-Flash as free, but I do not track those three.
- **Free units.** TypeSafe Jev output is $0. Amazon Nova cache writes are $0. Z.ai and Xiaomi cache writes are free for a limited time.
- **Free allowances.** Anthropic code execution includes 1,550 free hours per organization per month. Google grounding includes 5,000 requests per month. OpenAI includes 1 GB of file storage, and OpenAI moderation is free.
- **Free trial credit.** Anthropic gives new users "a small amount of free credits."

MODELS THAT USE IT

30 of 106 models carry at least one $0 price line: Z.ai 18, TypeSafe 4, Amazon 3, Xiaomi 3, Google 2. Two tracked models are entirely free: Gemma 4 12B and Gemma 4 31B. Z.ai's three free Flash models are on the vendor's list but not among the 106 I track.

THINGS TO WATCH

- A free tier can carry a data cost. Google's free tier states "Content used to improve our products."
- A $0 line with no first-party source looks exactly like a missing price.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Use free allowances for development and evaluation traffic.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Recording an unknown price as $0. A $0 line should carry its source and the vendor's own word "free."

NAME · MECHANISM 7 OF 18

07 Speed, Priority and "Highspeed" Tiers

29 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

You pay more for faster output or for priority admission. Vendors sell this either as a request flag on the same model or as a separate model ID.

EXAMPLE

MODEL	TIER	PRICE	STANDARD
OpenAI gpt-6-astra	Fast (renamed from Priority on July 30, 2026), 2x	$20/$100	$10/$50
OpenAI gpt-6-astra	Ultrafast, 6x	$60/$300	$10/$50
Anthropic Opus 5.5	Fast mode, 2x	$8/$40	$4/$20
Google Gemini 4 Argon	Priority, 1.8x	$3.60/$18.00	$2.00/$10.00
MiniMax M3	Priority, 1.5x	$0.45/$1.80	$0.30/$1.20
Moonshot kimi-k3.1-pro-highspeed	Separate model ID	$4.00 input, $0.20 cached, $4.00 5-minute write, $20.00 output	$2.00, $0.20, $2.00, $10.00
Xiaomi mimo-v2.6-pro-ultraspeed	Separate model ID, 10x	$4.35/$8.70	$0.435/$0.87
xAI	Priority, 2x	UNVERIFIED (from my October 20 review)	Not verified

Anthropic fast mode on Opus 5 and Opus 4.8 is $10/$50. It stacks with caching and data residency, and it is not available with batch.

MODELS THAT USE IT

29 exposed models: OpenAI 13, Google 9, Anthropic 3, MiniMax 1, plus 3 separate highspeed model IDs.

THINGS TO WATCH

- The multiplier is not uniform. I see 1.5x, 1.8x, 2x, 6x and 10x in published prices.
- Moonshot Highspeed doubles input and output but keeps the cached read at $0.20.
- A tier flag on the request can silently raise the price if a client library sets it.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Reserve speed tiers for user-facing paths where latency matters, and keep them off background work.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Passing a tier flag through to a vendor when the platform bills at standard rates. Either price the multiplier or reject the flag.

08 Container and Session Runtime Fees

NAME · MECHANISM 8 OF 18

28 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

The vendor charges by time for a sandbox or an agent session, separately from tokens.

EXAMPLE

PRODUCT	PRICE	RULES
Anthropic code execution	$0.05 per container-hour after 1,550 free hours per month	5-minute minimum. Free when used with the newer web search or fetch tools. Files in the request start billing even if the tool is never called.
Anthropic Managed Agents	$0.08 per session-hour	Counted only while the session is "running."
OpenAI Hosted Shell and Code Interpreter	$0.03 (1 GB) to $1.92 (64 GB) per 20-minute session	Billed by the minute, with a 5-minute minimum.
Google code execution	No runtime charge	Tokens only.

MODELS THAT USE IT

28 exposed models: OpenAI 16, Anthropic 12.

THINGS TO WATCH

- Memory size multiplies OpenAI's price 64-fold.
- Minimum billable durations make many short calls expensive.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Reuse a container across steps.
- Pick the smallest memory class that does the job.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Attaching files "just in case" on Anthropic. The attachment starts the meter.

NAME · MECHANISM 9 OF 18

09 Data Residency and Regional Price Lists

23 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

The vendor adds a surcharge to keep processing inside a named geography, or publishes a separate price list for each region.

EXAMPLE

- Anthropic's inference_geo: "us" setting is 1.1x on every token category for Claude 4.6 and later.
- Claude on Amazon Bedrock regional endpoints and Google Cloud multi-region endpoints carries a 10 percent premium over global endpoints.
- OpenAI regional processing and FedRAMP endpoints carry a 10 percent uplift for models released on or after March 5, 2026.
- Xiaomi publishes separate China (RMB) and overseas (USD) tables. MiMo-V2.6-Pro input is ¥3.00 on one and $0.435 on the other. The Tencent Hunyuan prices in my Tariff are Singapore-region prices. Alibaba Model Studio publishes an International (Singapore) list.

MODELS THAT USE IT

23 exposed models: 11 Claude models with US-only inference, plus 12 models priced from a region-specific list (Alibaba 7, Xiaomi 3, Tencent 2). Which OpenAI models carry the uplift depends on each model's release date, and that count is UNVERIFIED.

THINGS TO WATCH

- The surcharge multiplies every other mechanism, including fast mode and long-context bands.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Use residency only for data that requires it, and route the rest globally.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Accepting a residency parameter on a route that bills global rates.

NAME · MECHANISM 10 OF 18

10 Prompt-Size (Long Context) Bands

22 models

DESCRIPTION

When the prompt crosses a threshold, the whole request reprices at a higher band. The higher price applies to every token in the request, not only the tokens above the line.

EXAMPLE

MODEL	THRESHOLD	STANDARD	ABOVE THRESHOLD
OpenAI gpt-5.5	Above 272,000 input tokens	$5/$30	$10/$45
xAI grok-4.7	200,000 prompt tokens or more	$2.00/$6.00	$4.00/$12.00, "for all tokens in the request"
Google Gemini 2.5 Pro	Above 200,000	$1.25/$10	$2.50/$15
Anthropic Claude Haiku 5.5	Above 100,000 (cache reads count toward it)	$0.10/$0.50	$0.50/$2.50 (5x)
MiniMax M3	Above 512,000	$0.30/$1.20	$0.60/$2.40
Alibaba Qwen 3.7 Plus	Above 256,000	$0.40/$1.60	$1.20/$4.80

The counter-example is Anthropic. Claude 4.6 and later, except Haiku 5.5, bill the full 1M-token window at standard rates.

MODELS THAT USE IT

22 models: OpenAI 9, xAI 8, Google 2, Anthropic 1, MiniMax 1, Alibaba 1.

THINGS TO WATCH

- One token over the line can double the cost of the entire request.
- Thresholds differ by vendor, and so does the boundary. OpenAI's line is ">272K" and xAI's is "≥200K".

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Trim or summarize context to stay under the threshold.
- Retrieve the passages a request needs instead of stuffing whole documents into the prompt.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Estimating cost from a blended average. Price each request against its own band.

NAME · MECHANISM 11 OF 18

11 Cache Write Priced by Retention Time (TTL)

22 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

The longer the vendor holds the cache, the more the write costs.

EXAMPLE

MODEL	SHORT RETENTION WRITE	LONG RETENTION WRITE
Anthropic Opus 5.5	5-minute: $5 (1.25x input)	1-hour: $8 (2x input)
OpenAI gpt-6-astra	30-minute: $12.50	12-hour: $25.00 (2x the 30-minute)
Moonshot kimi-k3.1-pro	5-minute: $2.00	1-hour: $4.00
Moonshot kimi-k3.1-pro Highspeed	5-minute: $4.00	1-hour: $8.00
Moonshot kimi-k3	5-minute: $3.00	1-hour: $6.00

Moonshot selects the retention time with a request option, prompt_cache_options.ttl.

MODELS THAT USE IT

22 exposed models: Anthropic 12, OpenAI 7, Moonshot 3.

THINGS TO WATCH

- A platform that stores only one write column bills the long-retention write at the short-retention price. On Kimi K3.1 Pro that is $2.00 billed against $4.00 owed.
- Each vendor uses a different request field to select retention, so a check written for one vendor's field misses another's.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Use the long retention only when the gaps between reuses exceed the short window. On Anthropic it needs two reads to break even.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Metering one retention time and passing the other through unpriced. Either price every retention column or refuse the long-retention option.

12

NAME · MECHANISM 12 OF 18

Flex (Slow, Cheap Synchronous) Tier

22 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

The request stays synchronous but accepts slower or interruptible service in exchange for a batch-like discount.

EXAMPLE

MODEL	STANDARD	FLEX
OpenAI gpt-6-astra	$10/$50	$5/$25
Google Gemini 4 Argon	$2/$10	$1/$5

MODELS THAT USE IT

22 exposed models: OpenAI 13, Google 9. Whether Gemini 3.7 Flash offers batch, Flex and Priority is UNVERIFIED. Google's page does not show it as its own section, so my nine-model Gemini counts exclude it.

THINGS TO WATCH

- Flex trades availability for price. Expect slower responses or capacity errors.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Use Flex for non-urgent synchronous jobs that cannot be restructured as batch.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Retrying a failed Flex request on Fast without a cost check.

NAME · MECHANISM 13 OF 18

13 Hidden Token Overhead

13 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

These are tokens you pay for but did not write: tool system prompts, tool definitions, tokenizer changes and fixed blocks.

EXAMPLE

- Anthropic adds a tool-use system prompt of 286 tokens (Opus 5.5) to 675 tokens (Opus 4.7) whenever tools are present. The computer-use toolset adds about 4,500 input tokens and the browser toolset about 6,600.
- Claude 4.7 and later use a tokenizer that "produces approximately 30% more tokens for the same text."
- OpenAI bills web search content for gpt-4o-mini and gpt-4.1-mini as a fixed block of 8,000 input tokens per call.

MODELS THAT USE IT

13 exposed models. All 12 tracked Claude models carry tool overhead, and 9 of them also use the newer tokenizer. The thirteenth is OpenAI gpt-4.1-mini, under the fixed 8,000-token search block. The other model named in that OpenAI rule, gpt-4o-mini, is not one I track.

THINGS TO WATCH

- A model with a lower list price can cost more per task if it emits 30 percent more tokens.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Compare models on cost per completed task, not cost per token.
- Declare only the tools a request needs.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Carrying old per-token benchmarks across a tokenizer change.

NAME · MECHANISM 14 OF 18

14 Reasoning (Thinking) Tokens Billed as Output

10+ verified models

DESCRIPTION

Internal reasoning tokens bill at the output price, even when the vendor hides or encrypts them.

EXAMPLE

- Google labels every Gemini output price "including thinking tokens." Gemini 4 Argon output is $10.00.
- Alibaba Qwen 3.6-35B-A3B lists one $2.25 output price for "thinking and non-thinking."
- xAI's Responses API always returns encrypted reasoning content for grok-4.7.

MODELS THAT USE IT

At least 10 verified models (9 paid Gemini models whose page sections carry the "including thinking tokens" label, plus 1 at Alibaba), and in practice most models that can reason. No tracked vendor publishes a separate thinking-token price.

THINGS TO WATCH

- Reasoning effort settings change output volume, often by multiples, at the same unit price.
- DeepSeek defaults to thinking mode.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Set the lowest reasoning effort that passes your quality bar.
- Use non-thinking modes for simple tasks.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Forecasting output cost from the length of the visible answer.

15 Cache and File Storage by Time

NAME · MECHANISM 15 OF 18

8 exposed models

DESCRIPTION

The vendor charges to keep data available, priced per token-hour or per GB-day.

EXAMPLE

ITEM	PRICE
Gemini context cache storage	$0.50 per million tokens per hour through December 31, 2026, then $1.00 from January 1, 2027
OpenAI file search storage	$0.10 per GB per day after 1 GB free
OpenAI ChatKit upload storage	$0.10 per GB per day after 1 GB free
Z.ai cached input storage	"Limited-time Free"

MODELS THAT USE IT

8 exposed Gemini models with explicit caching. OpenAI file storage applies to every OpenAI model that uses file search.

THINGS TO WATCH

- A 1M-token Gemini cache held for 24 hours costs $12 in storage today and $24 from January 1, 2027, before a single read.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Set short cache lifetimes.
- Delete stores you no longer query.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Long-lived explicit caches on low-traffic prompts.

16

NAME · MECHANISM 16 OF 18

Promotional Pricing and Dated Step-Ups

6 models

DESCRIPTION

The vendor publishes a price with an announced end date, or schedules an increase in advance.

EXAMPLE

MODEL	CURRENT PRICE	WHAT CHANGES
Google Gemini 4 Argon	$2/$10 through November 30, 2026	$4/$20 from December 1, 2026
Google Gemini 3.8, 3.7 and 3.6 Flash	$0.75/$3.75 through December 31, 2026	$1.50/$7.50 from January 1, 2027
OpenAI GPT-5.6 Sol	Promotional pricing "available at least through November 21, 2026"	No successor price stated
MiniMax M3	"Permanent 50% off" list	No end date
Anthropic Sonnet 5 (context, not counted) [3]	Introductory $2/$10 became the standard price	The planned September 1 increase to $3/$15 was cancelled

[3] Context, not counted. Anthropic announced Sonnet 5 at an introductory $2/$10 through August 31, 2026, then made it the standard price and cancelled the planned September 1 increase to $3/$15. No dated change remains, so Sonnet 5 is not among the 6.

MODELS THAT USE IT

6 models: 4 with dated step-ups already recorded (Gemini 4 Argon and Gemini 3.8, 3.7 and 3.6 Flash), plus GPT-5.6 Sol and MiniMax M3. The "Permanent 50% off" label is on M3 only, not M3.1-Flash.

THINGS TO WATCH

- Promotions without end dates, such as the Z.ai and Xiaomi "limited-time free" lines, can end without notice.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Load the successor price with its start date ahead of time, so billing changes on the right day.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Carrying promotional prices into budgets or contracts past the stated end date.

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Time-of-Day and Day-of-Week Bands

3 models

DESCRIPTION

The same model costs different amounts depending on when the request runs.

EXAMPLE

DeepSeek's off-peak rates are half of peak. Peak runs 01:00 to 04:00 and 06:00 to 10:00 UTC, Monday through Friday, excluding Chinese public holidays. Weekends and Chinese public holidays are off-peak all day.

MODEL	PEAK	OFF-PEAK
deepseek-flash	$0.30/$1.20	$0.15/$0.60
deepseek-v4-pro	$1.32/$3.96	$0.66/$1.98

MODELS THAT USE IT

3 models from one vendor, DeepSeek.

THINGS TO WATCH

- Peak falls in the US evening and overnight: 8:00 PM to 11:00 PM and 1:00 AM to 5:00 AM Central time, Sunday night through Friday morning, under daylight time.
- The holiday calendar is Chinese, not American. A meter that ignores it overbills on those days.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Schedule DeepSeek batch-style jobs for US business hours and weekends.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Pricing all DeepSeek traffic at one band.

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18 Legacy Model Names Billed as a Different Model

1 tracked model

DESCRIPTION

An old model name keeps working, but a different model serves the request and sets the bill.

EXAMPLE

- DeepSeek: "The legacy names deepseek-v4-flash and deepseek-v4-flash-vision-exp are still accepted, but the corresponding models have been retired, their requests are served by the DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash-1017 model and billed at the Flash price."
- xAI points unversioned names and "-latest" names at newer releases.

MODELS THAT USE IT

1 tracked model: the legacy name deepseek-v4-flash, which DeepSeek serves with DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash-1017 and bills at the same price as the current deepseek-flash ($0.30/$1.20 peak, $0.15/$0.60 off-peak). xAI documents its naming rule, but I have not verified which tracked xAI names point to newer releases, so I do not count them.

THINGS TO WATCH

- The price can stay the same while the model changes, or the reverse.

WAYS TO OPTIMIZE

- Pin dated model versions in production.

THINGS TO AVOID

- Billing one model's price for another model's output without recording the substitution.

How the Mechanisms Stack

Vendors publish how their multipliers combine. On Anthropic, cache multipliers stack on fast mode, data residency stacks on fast mode, batch and caching combine, and fast mode is not available with batch.

Anthropic's own worked example: a one-hour Managed Agents session on Opus 5.5 with 50,000 input tokens and 15,000 output tokens costs $0.58 ($0.20 input, $0.30 output, $0.08 runtime). If 40,000 of those input tokens are cache reads, the session costs $0.428.

The order I use for a billing system: select the prompt-size band, then apply multipliers (speed, residency).

Methodology

Built from vendors' public announcements and pricing pages across 106 tracked models, checked October 2026.

Appendix B. Claims Labeled UNVERIFIED

1. UNVERIFIED. xAI server tool fees of $2.50 to $10 per 1,000 calls (Mechanism 3).
2. UNVERIFIED. xAI priority tier at 2x (Mechanism 7).
3. UNVERIFIED. DeepSeek V4 Pro cache write of $0.435. DeepSeek's current page publishes no write price (Mechanism 4).
4. UNVERIFIED. Mistral batch and priority rates, and xAI batch rates (Mechanism 5).
5. UNVERIFIED. Which OpenAI models carry the 10 percent residency uplift for models released on or after March 5, 2026 (Mechanism 9).
6. UNVERIFIED. Gemini 3.7 Flash batch, Flex and Priority availability. It is not shown as its own section on Google's page, and the nine-model Gemini counts exclude it (Mechanism 12).

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